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Hal Espinosa

Beginning with a distinguished career as a trumpeter, Hal Espinosa eventually became President of AFM Local 47 in Los Angeles, where he negotiated contracts for movies, jazz casuals, recording dates, orchestral musicians, and the majority of musical activity in and around Los Angeles for ten years.

Hal was interviewed via Zoom on March 20, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Hal Espinosa with me today. Welcome.

HE: Thanks for having me on.

MR: And congratulations on your career. I should introduce you as a trumpet player and former president of the professional musicians' Local 47, which was a pretty healthy organization over the years I would imagine.

HE: Yes it was. It really was. Had a lot of fun doing that.

MR: We're going to get to that. You kind of tweaked my memory before we started recording about the way things used to be. And you mentioned the ice man delivering ice and I was talking about the milkman. And just yesterday I was doing some research on something and I happened to look at the top popular songs of 1950. It makes me wonder, you would have been 15 years old at that time and I assume that you had started the trumpet?

HE: Yes. I actually started when I was eleven. I went and saw a movie when I was in the seventh grade and it was Harry James, and he was the feature. He was the guy that was the focal point, and his band. And I remember Dick Haymes I think was in it and then a girl singer. And I went away wanting to play a trumpet because Harry was in front of the band playing. He won the singer away from I think Dick Haymes, whoever the other boy singer was. I went home and asked my dad, you know, if I could get a trumpet. So he went to a music store and got me a $40 cornet because it was cheaper. So I started in the seventh grade and brought it home and occasionally picked it up and practiced. And then when I was in the eighth grade my band director in junior high school — junior high school at that time was from seventh, eighth and ninth grade. So in the eighth grade, at the end of the eighth grade, the music director told me if I would take lessons from him over the summer he'd make me a first chair as a ninth grader. So I thought okay, I can do that. So I mowed lawns and got the $3 for a half hour lesson and I'd have to bicycle about 2-1/2 miles to his place and back. And I was first chair. So the high school — I'm from Riverside, California. I'm actually a sixth generation Californian. So when I got to be

good player, I was just in the ninth grade. So the high school in Riverside, there's only one high school, Riverside Polytechnic High. And they had a great band and they had — there were three junior high schools that fed into the high school so they picked all three first chair junior high players to put in the advanced band. So I was next to last chair. And they were supposed to have a concert the next day at an elementary school, you know, a big thing for us. And so the trumpet player, the first trumpet player, had a solo. And while we were rehearsing the tune he messed up the trumpet solo right from the beginning. So Mr. Oaks, our band director, slammed down the baton, looked over his glasses at him and said, "Okay let's start from Letter C" (the trumpet solo). He wasn't prepared for that and then he screwed it up worse. And then a third time, just as bad. So he went to the second player. He wasn't prepared. He missed it. And so he went right down the row of trumpets. When it got to me I was shaking. When I started playing he threw down the baton and said, "What are you doing even playing the trumpet? You sound like a billy goat." And he embarrassed me so much that if there would have been a hole I would have crawled in to it. He was the one that motivated me to start practicing. Because when I went home I started practicing between three to five hours and then pretty soon it was four to six hours every day after school because I was going to show him I could play the trumpet. So that's where I started.

MR: I love that because there's two spots in that story where I thought it was going somewhere and it didn't. I thought you know it finally got to you and you played it beautifully.

HE: I would have liked to.

MR: Yes. But then the fact that he embarrassed you and instead of quitting you went the other direction.

HE: Yeah.

MR: So going back to this list, if you're thinking about eventually a career as a trumpet player, I was just interested in a few of the songs off this list from 1950 and we have the "Tennessee Waltz" by Patti Page, "Cry of the Wild Goose" by Frankie Laine, and the "Third Man Theme" by the fellow who used to play on New Year's Eve, remember Guy Lombardo?

HE: I remember them all.

MR: I guess my point is the big band era had faded out for the most part. What were your aspirations and how did you see that playing a trumpet could be a career?

HE: Well you know at that time I never thought of playing the trumpet as a career. It was just a fun thing to do and it became more fun as I got better naturally, and then finally I got to be on first chair in high school. And I was really into sports except I'm not tall and I'm

high school but when I got to high school all these kids that were my size or a couple of inches taller just grew like a foot taller. So finally I, you know the fact that I was practicing a lot a couple of guys from the high school band went to Arizona State on scholarships, and they'd come back and tell me, "Harold, you've got to audition for a scholarship." So I thought why not, I'll do that. So two of us went over and I got a scholarship. So at that time I got free tuition plus $100 for the year. You know to buy books and things like that. And my dad worked for the railroad so I got free transportation over to Tempe, Arizona from Riverside at that time, so there was no cost there. So I really didn't plan on playing professionally, I just wanted to go to college. Went to college but then in the band I was able — they saw me as a hot shot trumpet player from California. I was no hot shot but I can hold my own fairly well. So then some guys in Phoenix heard about me and had me play professionally with them. I was 17 and Nat King Cole came into town and there's one restaurant — not restaurant, but a, oh what would I call it — a regular club where there's entertainment. And Nat King Cole came in, I worked for him for a week at 17 and I thought wow, you know, everything — love this. And then pretty soon Ted — what's his last name, he always had the top hat?

MR: Fio Rito?

HE: No.

MR: Oh yeah, I know who you mean.

HE: He goes way back. But I think he fooled around with the clarinet. And it's been so long ago I don't remember now. But anyway I worked for him. And then a movie came into town and I got to do some sidelining on a movie and I thought you know this is really a great way to make money. And I was making money then as a kid playing in these jobs. And I'd do a few casuals while I was in college. So only then did I start thinking I wonder if I could ever be good enough to play professionally. Because in high school I'd hear Les Brown playing "Leap Frog" and I'd try to do it and [scats] crack-crack. And pretty soon I got it down pretty good.

MR: Was the concept of — were you aware of the concept of what they called the "jazz chair" in the big bands at that point?

HE: Right. I was.

MR: And how did you — what did you do to make it possible for you to sit in the jazz chair?

HE: Well like when I first got on Woody's band he had two jazz players. One was Don Rader who we became like brothers and really good friends. He did the main jazz chair. And then I sat on the other end and there wasn't much jazz and fortunately the jazz I had was in a Harmon mute in a mic and that was easy because I thought nobody can hear this. But you know all the time growing up through the school system there was always a good

play and not me. And finally I don't know if you've ever heard of this trumpet player Louie Valizan. He was with Esquivel! for a long time, he was with Perez Prado playing the high notes. He was just far beyond his age when I used to work with him with a little Latin band. And he played like Dizzy, he played double C's — this was when he was 20 and I was 17. And there were two of us, two trumpet players. And he'd say, "You play a solo." And I'd say, "No," you know not after what I was hearing from you. I'd be terrible. So every opportunity I had I gave it to somebody else. So I wasn't really into that if there was somebody better than me. If there weren't any good jazz players then I'd go ahead and play. And I'd do okay but you know if I was going to be a jazz player I'd want to play like Chet Baker or Don Fagerquist at that time, those were my idols in jazz. And you know I memorized a lot of Chet Baker solos at the time. So I could fool around with that if the chord structure was proper and I was playing a solo. But there was always somebody in every band that was really a good soloist so I just kind of shied away from, and started doing my thing as the lead player.

MR: I have a quote here from this book about Woody Herman.

HE: I'm sure I am not in it, I was only on the band about —

MR: Well you get a mention. Would you like to hear the mention?

HE: Sure.

MR: It said, "In the summer of 1960 many guys passed through the band, it mentions a lot of names, and in the trumpet section Burt Collins, Ziggy Harrel, Hal Espinosa, and Bill Berry. The turnover was very high, probably because the bread was low.

HE: It was low.

MR: What is low bread back then?

HE: $135 for the section players. Bill Chase was getting $175.

MR: This is per week?

HE: Per week. And in the section when I was there it was Bill Chase, myself, Gerry Lamy, Don Rader, and John Bennett and we were the trumpet section. And we all got — I think I finally got $150 but I used to ride with Woody you know. Because at that time when we were on the road here on the east coast we'd go to motels or mainly hotels in the city and sleep. That was where we ended up all the time. And we could get a hotel room for two guys each, about $4 and $5 apiece for the room, and sometimes it might be $5 or $6. Well nobody wanted to travel with Woody. Woody had a 1960 Corvette. And all the guys, you know back then they all turned on, we even had a couple of junkies in the band. And so anyway I rode with Woody because nobody wanted to ride with Woody because then they couldn't turn on. So I was the clean little young kid because I was the youngest one in the band, I rode with Woody and he was a sweetheart. And any time we

keys to the Corvette. And I'd have Don Rader come with me. Here we are — Don is maybe barely 5' tall, and I'm maybe 5'7" at best. So we'd pull up the Corvette into like a West Virginia gas station and these guys in coveralls are leaning their chairs against the front of the gas station just like you'd see in the movies. And pretty soon they got up and they'd walk around the car and the engine would come up so they could check the oil. There was about three guys looking in the engine. And here's two young guys — I was I think 25 and Don was I think — well Don was just about three months younger than me — six months. So you know we made an impression. But it was a lot of fun and the fact that nobody wanted to ride with Woody and I did, it was just fun for me.

MR: I can imagine you at the gas station, the guy's going, "What are you all doing here?" "Well we play with Woody Herman." They'd go like, "What's a Woody Herman?"

HE: Exactly. And one funny thing is when we were on the road, Abe Turchin — I think that was his name — he was the booker for Woody. And he was actually siphoning money from Woody and Woody didn't realize it. But he booked us in a barn someplace in the south. I'm not sure whether it was in Arkansas, Alabama, someplace. But we were in the hills. And it was a big barn. People came in with coveralls and women with long dresses and wide dresses, and we are playing jazz, and then we'd play dance music too for them. There might have been maybe 100 people, 125 people there. But he booked that just for transportation. I think Woody made $500 for that night, maybe $400.

MR: For the whole band?

HE: Yeah. For the whole band for a four hour job. But that's when I was still riding in cars with the other guys.

MR: Did you ever get pulled over in that Corvette?

HE: No. Woody drove fast but we never got pulled over although one time going into, not New Orleans, but Biloxi, there's a kind of a bridge going over a train track I think and there's a signal light just as we started going down the other side and another thing attached to the bridge, you know another roadway. And as soon as — he was passing slow trucks and as we started going down he saw a red light. He had to slam on the brakes, the truck came back and bumped the back of his Corvette. Didn't do any damage to our instruments or anything, but that's as close as we got to having been stopped, you know, by police.

MR: What did you learn about human nature? This is a pretty broad question but in your travels with various bands did you learn anything about human nature that stuck with you?

HE: You know not really. You know at that time I was young and just wanted to see the country and I was able to do that. I was actually being a professional in something I never

time, playing music that at the time I said if this is all I did the rest of my life — play this music — that's all I'd ever want to do because the music was so much fun. I never played lead although the first time I was on Woody's band I was playing like I said on one of the ends, Don was on the other end. And then Woody broke the band up because they just didn't have any takers for booking the band at that time, so they disbanded the band. Bill Chase and Woody stayed on and they had a little quintet. And I went with the old Tommy Dorsey band when Warren Covington had it. So I did that for about, I don't even remember, maybe five, six months. And then Woody got the band together again. He had tours happening. So I went back. This time I played split lead with Bill Chase. And so that's the closest I got to playing lead with Woody. But Bill was a very good lead player, knew how to lay back, and swing, and there would be times when I'd play his part for about four bars starting to go up the register so I could take the mouthpiece off of its lip so you can start back down from a high G going up. So it was fun for me and fun, I'm sure, for him. Then after that I ended up getting a call from this guy, a tenor sax player called — I think his name was Bob McCoy. And he was a contractor for Buddy Morrow's band. And Buddy was looking for a lead player and they were going to offer me $175 a week if I would take it. And I thought $175, I'm making I think it was $150 then. So I took it. And then after I left that's when Sal Nistico came on the band and — I can't think of the drummer — the brain, you know, as you get older things start hiding in your head. All the old memories.

MR: That's for sure.

HE: But Jimmy Campbell was the drummer the whole time I was on Woody's band until I left and that's when he left and then Jake Hanna came in. So — and then Phil Wilson came in too I think. Jimmy went — left probably just after I did.

MR: Were you surprised years later when Bill Chase had success in the rock world?

HE: I was surprised. You know when — I was offered a job at Basin Street East by Leo Ball, who is a trumpet player in New York, well known and a good politician. You know I played with some rehearsal bands in New York when I was there a few times. And so he liked what I was doing and he asked me if I would work with him at Basin Street East, he was getting a trumpet section. So we had maybe three or four weeks 'til it started. So I gave Buddy my notice and right after I did that I got a call from a trumpet player that I worked with on Warren Covington's Tommy Dorsey band, who had been working in Vegas for a year. And he called and he said, "I've got a job playing lead at the Tropicana across the street from the Dunes Hotel and I could get a job immediately for $250 a week. And Basin Street East was scale in New York at that time, it was $135 a week.

MR: What year was this? Can you remind me what year?

HE: It was 1963, January I think is when I started in Vegas. And scale in Vegas I think was $176 — it was actually higher than New York at that time. So $250 a week then was big time money. And they had to import people into Vegas at that time, the union wouldn't allow people to come in and just start working, you know a steady job. You had to wait six months. And they could do casuals but they couldn't land a steady job until after six months that they were there. But they got a waiver for this Viva La Girls show that I was doing at the Dunes Hotel. I ended up — I was guaranteed one year of work. I ended up being there four years.

MR: Can you, for our people who view this, define "casual."

HE: Oh the dance jobs, you know maybe an award show, a conference, a convention, playing music for people like that.

MR: Okay just not a steady week after week type gig.

HE: No. Just casuals. That's what we used to call them back then.

MR: How old were you when you joined the musicians' union?

HE: Well Riverside, California had a union then and they wanted me to play a show that the Orange County Festival in San Bernardino, the largest city in Riverside at the time, at the county fair. But you had to be union, so they paid for my union fees. I don't know what it was but I was able to play and that was at 16. So that was fun for me because they brought in some guys from L.A. that were much older and professional players.

MR: You didn't have to audition to get in then?

HE: No.

MR: I have a little story here from Derek Smith, the late pianist who came over from England to New York. And of course he went to the musicians' union 'cause he wanted to start working and they said, "Six months, come back in six months." So he did. And when he got there the person said okay there's an audition and this is a quote from him: "So I go into this room, there's the piano. And the guy said, 'What's that instrument over there?' So I said, 'What are you talking about? It's a piano.' He says, 'You're in now go upstairs and pay your hundred dollars.'"

HE: That was a good audition. You know I only auditioned twice in my life. One was to get the scholarship at Arizona State and the other is when I got drafted after I graduated from Arizona State I was drafted in the Army. And after the six month — I mean six weeks of Basic Training then they'd send you to Advanced Training — I think that's what they called it. And I asked if I could audition for the band. So they sent me to the band, and there's this little cornet player. He had — well I was 25 then I think — 24 or 25 or no, 24. 23 or 24. Anyway this guy took me in and he looked like he had to be 55 or 60 years old, you know some wrinkled faces and sergeant, you know the whole thing. Just the nicest

"Okay, you're in." So I spent my two years at Fort Ord right outside of Monterey, California, which is a beautiful area, so I never had to really go overseas. It was just after the Korean War. I had some friends in college that entered going in the war to Korea. So I was able to bypass that because I was deferred going to college all that time. And as soon as I graduated I got my greetings.

MR: So you ended up in a different way going to a war with Bob Hope. Is that correct?

HE: Um hum.

MR: I'm interested in that, how that — what that was like going to Vietnam and playing those tours.

HE: Well I told people that's the highlight of my career because when I left Vegas, I ended up being in Vegas for six years. I played at The Dunes for four years. The other — there were two trumpets. One was Charlie Turner, who is an excellent trumpet player. He ended up traveling with Frank Sinatra for a couple of years, and myself. He had 60% of the lead, I had 40% approximately. A hard, hard book. That's the hardest show I've ever worked in my life. It was music by the pound. And on one show, the first show we had a minute and 20 seconds' rest out of an hour and 15 minutes show. So the rest was just a bar here, five bars, six bars, and on. Just kept playing. That's why I was able to, you know, leave New York and go right into that job because they didn't have anybody that was available that could handle that. And fortunately, working with Woody and then Buddy Morrow, I was playing lead and I was practicing all the time. I was taking from Maurice Grupp, the little sax player but he taught breathing and he was a little old man then and Bob McCoy, another trumpet player who I met at — well I can't remember the name of the ballroom where the union guys used to hang to get jobs — Rose Room — no Rose Room? Rose something or other. And I saw Bob there and met him, and we needed a couple of trumpet players so he was one of them, and he just played great. But anyway, where was I going with this?

MR: I was wondering what the various conditions were like when you were playing for the service men and women in Vietnam. They would set up a stage for you and carry your own sound system?

HE: Oh that's right. I just went way to the right, didn't I?

MR: That's okay, we can go right and left.

HE: But when I ended up leaving Vegas after six years I went into L.A. instead of working. I befriended Buddy — God how can I forget his name? Lead player with Stan Kenton.

MR: Childers? Buddy Childers?

HE: Buddy Childers. Yes, God. He was another like brother to me. I didn't know him, I knew of him in high school looking at the back of Stan Kenton albums. So he was having

Buddy to see if he could take my place for a week. He did and he just really thanked me because I helped him when he was in a down part of his life. And then he moved to L.A. He said, "When you come into L.A. call me." So I did maybe a year later and he remembered — he took me with him to dates because he had burned his bridge the first time around with all his contractor friends. When he came back the second time he was okay with it and started working. And I got a phone call from Butch Stone. He was the contractor for Les Brown's band, asked if I — he'd heard about me from different guys so he said there was a chair open. So I went there. I didn't know which chair, there was a chair open. When I got there everybody was in their chairs except for the lead chair. I thought uh oh, I've got to sight read this book. So I got up there, met Les and then the other trumpet players. And fortunately I was a pretty good reader and I had iron chops from doing those shows in Vegas like I did for six years. So I got up there and — after we're playing for 15, 20 minutes and I'm looking down at Les all the time, he's always staring up at me and I thought uh oh, he doesn't like what I'm doing. But I'm thinking I'm not screwing anything up, I must not be phrasing properly or something. So after the first hour Les called me and said, "Let's go to the bar." So he bought me a drink and he's puffing on his cigar — I mean his pipe — and he's saying, "Hal, I need a first trumpet player because Don Smith, my regular trumpet player, is on staff at NBC and we're taking a tour through the south and I'd like you to be my first chair player and when we come back it's your job. So I was ecstatic. I said, "You've got me Les, I'm ready." And the first year, you know I didn't realize I don't think that he was doing the Bob Hope Show, I guess I did know — the Bob Hope Show and Dean Martin TV show. So as soon as I joined the band we started doing the Bob Hope Show and then along with that came the Christmas show. So we got all kinds of shots, got probably six or seven shots each — you know malaria and all kinds of other stuff. Because we'd go into jungle areas then into Alaska where it's freezing in the same two week time. So when we would fly to Bangkok that was our home away from home. Every day we'd fly over to Vietnam, about a two hour flight. I think it was about two hours, maybe less. And they wouldn't tell us where we were going until we got on the plane and then they'd issue us our information where we were going to the first job. And we would land, I think it was a 1 — a 130 — I don't recall the names of the planes but they're the kinds that are small and on the side of the fuselage they had the netted seats. Like the parachute jumpers when they'd sit there and then hook up and then go off the chairs, that's what they flew us in. And so we'd land at the camp, put the show on. They'd have the stage already set. No cover in a lot of places. And in Vietnam it was 105, 110 degrees out because in December that's their summer. And we had a couple of guys, Butch Stone and Lou Ciotti, a tenor player, both

And the military always gave us their hats, you know, Squad 47 or whatever the names. I've got a collection of these caps in the garage that I kept all these years. But you know the troops, when we were through playing and performing, they'd come up to the band and thank us so much for being there, you know leaving home over Christmas to entertain them. And I thought then you know even if I didn't get paid I'd want to do this, just because of how I felt doing it.

MR: That's a great story. When we see movies about Vietnam now, usually the soundtrack are tunes from pop radio that were occurring during the Vietnam War — Sly & the Family Stone and that kind of thing. Yet you're saying that these young men were responding to music that had more to do with their parents than it did with them.

HE: Right. Yeah that was in 60- — I started in 1969 until Bob Hope's last trip which was in '72. He did '69, '70, '71 and '72. And you know the big band era, it started to fold I guess when Tommy Dorsey died. I did get a chance to work with Bob Crosby but he wasn't a big band then, but he was an old guy, an old band. But the bands were still working pretty well. Les Brown was working well, the road bands — you had road bands out there like Ray Anthony. And you know Ray Anthony is still alive. He's 102, and I used to work with him all the time. And I worked with Freddy Martin, another old time band leader. And he worked quite a bit. He did cruises along with Ray Anthony doing cruises. Harry James, he was alive then still touring. I worked with Harry. I went down to South America with him, and Billy Vaughan. You may have not have heard of him because he's not big in the U.S. He was big in Japan and South America. I took trips with him to Japan and to South America.

MR: I thought of the guy who you were trying to mention, I think was it Ted Lewis?

HE: Ted Lewis. He's the guy that had the hat on. He was the other name, entertainer, that I played when I was 17. It was like wow. And then Marie McDonald was another one. She was an actress back in the '50s and '60s.

MR: Were there any train wrecks or memorable things that happened in Vietnam besides the heat. I would imagine the bugs you know if you're playing like this?

HE: Well there weren't a lot of bugs that I remember but yeah we did have a couple of events. In fact the year before I joined, in 1968, the band used to stay in Saigon at the hotel there. And like I said, this was the year before I joined. But when the band was bussed over to the hotel just prior to getting there a Vietnamese put a bicycle, placed it in front of the hotel with explosives and blew up the side of the hotel. All the windows were smashed. Then the bus got through with the band and when they got in all the windows were smashed. But there were no bugs to get in the room and it was during the summer so they didn't have to worry about cold. But they did say if you see any packages don't open

rooms. So that was a funny thing. But that was before I got there. When I got there I remember we were in Da Nang performing. When we would land where the Freedom Hill was where they'd have 25,000 troops sitting up on the hill and they had a stage facing the hill. They'd bus us over to it, which was about a mile over to this hill, through a little village, a Vietnamese village. So there was a jeep in front of us with one of these machine guns in there and the guy's standing up with a machine gun and a jeep behind us with the same machine gun. And the bus that we were in they had real tight metal nets across the windows so nobody could launch a grenade in. So you're driving down this road, a dirt road, and you're looking at the village and there's dogs running around and Vietnamese people kind of looking up, and we're going through and I had a kind of an eerie feeling but anyway when we — after we did that show we got back in the plane — in fact that's coming back to me. The reason why we kind of left in a hurry was the sun was going down behind the hill and so we hadn't finished the show but the general in charge of the troops there jumped up on stage and had to interrupt Bob Hope and tell him, "Bob, we've got to dismiss the troops, the sun is going down, we can't take a chance." And they dismissed all the troops. They got us in our helicopters. They had helicopters to fly us down to the runway. We got in a plane and took off. And as we were taking off I could hear, well we could hear, "Bing bing bing." And ground fire hit our plane and then we swerved, came around and landed so they could check the fuselage and make sure no gas lines were hit. And after about 15 minutes they cleared the airfield and we took off and went back to Bangkok. So that was kind of a scary moment.

MR: I think that that probably put every other gig you played for the rest of your life in some kind of perspective.

HE: It did.

MR: You know we talk about — especially people with gear — oh Jeez, this gig is on the second floor, I've got to carry my keyboards up and all that stuff, and they didn't feed the band. And when I hear that description I just said yup, that's something to remember. I want to talk about music, musicians and technology for a bit. And it's connected to your role in the musicians' union. I came across this historical musical fact the other day and it said in 1927 the first talkie, "The Jazz Singer" was released, displacing orchestras in movie theaters. The AF of M had its first encounter with wholesale unemployment brought about by technology. 22,000 theater jobs for musicians who accompanied silent movies were lost while only a few hundred jobs for musicians performing on soundtracks were created by the new technology. And this kind of thing has followed music since then. When you became president of the professional Musicians' Local 47 what was the main concern at that time with technology and working musicians?

HE: Well at that time it went to — all these terms I'm kind of losing from my memory you know because I've been away from it for well I stepped down from office in 2009 so what's that 15 years ago? But they had the —

MR: Synthesizers and —

HE: It's not a synthesizer but it's similar to it where there's a keyboard player down there playing a whole score.

MR: Oh the virtual orchestra?

HE: The virtual orchestra. Thank you. That's the problem I had when I was president of the local. We had in our contracts with the theaters there a minimum of at least 18 musicians. New York — their minimums usually were like 24 for their largest theaters. And our theaters that we have in L.A. they were all larger than the largest one other than where the Rockettes perform. You know that's a big one. But at that time they were all maybe 1000 seats, 800 seats, 1200 maybe. Ours were like 1800 seats and similar to that, 1600 I think at the — one of them up in Beverly Hills. Anyway that's — instead of our minimum at 24, we had ours at 18 so that's what I inherited when I became president was 18. And they were trying to downsize the road musicians. So when it got to L.A. they wanted to have some of their musicians be put in the pit and eliminate some of our people like the drummer would be out, maybe the concertmaster, and that would be it. The others would have to go on vacation for three weeks or four weeks, at least two weeks because no show came to L.A. for less than a couple of weeks anyway. So even the old shows that came in they were there at least for two weeks. And there were times when I got to know the Neiderlanders — Jimmy Neiderlander, who owned you know half of Broadway at the time. I got to meet him. And one time they brought in a virtual orchestra. And replaced six of our musicians. So we had in our contract no virtual orchestra and 18 minimum. So we filed a grievance against them and we were going to go to arbitration. So we took them to arbitration. They brought over an attorney that was costing I figured around $500 an hour, this was in 2002. He flew out — he was from Washington, D.C. He flew out, stayed at the Peninsula Hotel in Beverly Hills, it started at $400 a night. And so Jimmy called me up after we had one arbitration hearing. Jimmy called me and he says, "Hal, why are you suing me?" Jimmy was like, had to be 70 at least then. I said, "Jimmy, we aren't suing you," I said, "Your people here in L.A. broke our agreement that we both signed. They brought in this virtual orchestra to replace six musicians." He said, "Well that's how the show operates, you know it comes in with that." I said, "Well then you've got to check the agreement and you need to call us and let us know, or tell them they can't come in with that virtual orchestra because we've got a minimum of musicians." So he says, "Well you know this is costing me $50,000 already." I said, "For the

$500 an hour." He said, "$600." So I was close. And then I said — he brought an assistant with him who had to be maybe $300 and they're staying at The Peninsula, I said it's cost — so you're paying his first class air, staying at the most expensive place in L.A., and I said, "The arbitration, we've only started this, we've got the two guys in New York who invented the virtual orchestra coming out, you know, for the hearing and the arbitration." And then we had Bill Moriarity, who was the president of New York at that time. We flew him out to be a witness about New York's contracts and how they can't be in there and why they shouldn't be in L.A. So anyway Jimmy said, "What can we do?" He said, "I don't want to spend any more money, what can we do to make this go away?" So I thought for a minute and I said, "Jimmy" there were six musicians that we had to cancel that were replaced on the first show and then the second show that came in two weeks later for two weeks, replaced six musicians. So I said, "If you paid their wages then maybe we can make this go away." But I said, "I'm going to have to talk to the musicians first to see if they're okay with that." So he said, "I'll get right back to you." No then he said, "How much do you think this is going to cost?" I said, thinking, "probably around $30,000." So he said, "Let me get back to you." So 15 minutes later I got this henchman on the phone saying, "Hal" and I knew him, he said, "Jimmy wants to make a deal. He'll pay six musicians for both shows." So I said, "Well it's not a done deal yet because I've got to have a meeting with the orchestra and see if they're okay with that." So they were. You know they took the money. But those are the kinds of things I dealt with with the theater pit. But prior to that when I was still playing the trumpet, you know back when I was a kid I went to see the Red Skelton Show at CBS and this is back in the early '50s when somebody screwed up on stage they had to stop and start all over again because they didn't have tape. Musicians, if they screwed up you heard the cracked note or a squeak or whatever it might have been at that time because they didn't have tape. I don't believe it was until maybe in the '60s when they got the tape because at that time we, you know we were working a whole lot more being rehearsal pianists for shows or dancers, you know performing, getting ready for a TV show or a movie. They made money. Then pretty soon after the tape, they'd record the musicians and the rhythm section and they'd just loop it and play it in rehearsals and cut musicians out. And they cut us out. So that was the beginning of new technology for us that we had to deal with. And in the theaters the main thing, motion pictures was another too because they started going down to smaller orchestras. And like New York would have maybe 10% of all the music that was done on union contracts. We did about 90% of all the musics that were done on union contracts. So we had the majority of them. But they were all usually 100, 110 piece orchestras, maybe some down to 90. Then pretty

soon they were 60 piece because the composer could do a synth and add different parts and so we were fighting all the time for pennies for musicians.

MR: It seems like I've seen quite a few movies that if you can wait through the credits it credits the London Symphony Orchestra as if a lot of those recordings have been done overseas.

HE: Well they did go overseas with a lot of them because they didn't have to pay re-use payments. And here, I still get, you know money, residuals, from movies I did back in 1970. I mean some of them might be 5¢, 15¢, $1.50, $25.00.

MR: You're in good company. I just got one for $1.64 I think but it was an ASCAP payment. You feel like putting those checks on the wall just for a little humor.

HE: But those are the movies that were done on a union contract. There were a lot of movies that were under the table. You know a contractor friend would call guys and get this movie and you'd do it, and you'd do it in pieces, maybe in somebody's garage do the rhythm section, then strings and brass and you'd pay in cash. And a lot of that went on. Some would go into a regular studio and that's when we'd kind of find out about it and send a union rep over there to see if they could bust it or keep the guys from going in.

MR: So the players would have been in the union for the most part?

HE: Right. I mean most of your good players were in the union. Jazz players were in the union, and then some, like I shouldn't mention his name but I will because he's gone now, but John Heard, the great bass player, he was in the union one time and then he quit because the union wasn't doing anything for him. He never got into motion pictures or TV or anything, he was strictly jazz in the bars. So I tried, when I was president, I was trying to get agreements with the bar owners to have a low scale for them, like they were paying at that time about 50 bucks a night for four hours to the jazz musicians, so I'd get them 50 plus 5 bucks for medical, 5 bucks for pension. Get it up to 60. And unfortunately the guys that were just doing club dates, they never qualified for medical and with so small going to the pension plan that they were losing that money so they're thinking why should I even be part of the union because that's all I am getting.

MR: Yeah it's the same here in Central New York for years. Most of the players are not full time musicians so the concept of getting a gig at a local club and then bringing up with the owner like, "Okay here's my union contract," that would just be something like, "what are you talking about?"

HE: I know it was difficult. And when I was president I was elected to the international executive board and it's like nine of us at that time telling everybody in the United States and Canada how they're supposed to work under union contract. And the small locals didn't like the large locals being part of that because we didn't think like they did. And

and Ed Ward, the president of Chicago we were big unions, they didn't like that because they didn't think we were thinking of them and yet we were telling them the music performance payment that you get to play your summer gigs from the Music Performance Trust Fund, that comes from musicians that record in New York, L.A., Chicago and Nashville. A certain amount of that money goes to create the Performance Fund. So you guys got that money by doing your concerts in the summertime. And so you know we aren't here to make you less than what you are, we're here to try to help you. You know a lot of your players come to the big cities to try to make it. A lot of them do make it and they're in L.A. and New York and the big cities where they can make some money. But I ran against the AFM president my last year, the couple of last years of my term in L.A. because he and I were having problems with the recording musicians in L.A. He didn't want to help us out, you know he fought us all the way in negotiations with motion picture and TV, so he was president of the AFM. So somebody ran against him before and lost so then one time at a conference Upstate New York I flew out to be there, and heard him put down the recording musicians. He specifically said the Los Angeles recording musicians blah-blah and just like really talked down about them. So I thought okay, I'm going to run against him. And I did and failed, because the little locals didn't want somebody from the big city because, you know, they aren't going to be taking care of the little locals until this last year. Finally Tino — I can't— [Gigliardi] — I can't remember Tino's last name but he was president of the New York local. He's now the AFM president. So they finally have a president from a large local, in fact it's the largest one in the country.

MR: I was talking to Tom Scott on an interview.

HE: The sax player?

MR: Yes, the sax player.

HE: Okay.

MR: And the subject of double scale and maybe triple scale came up. Was that something that the union had a role in?

HE: Yes.

MR: Or was it just economics?

HE: Yeah in a contract, especially in orchestras and motion pictures, if you're playing a principal chair it's always time and a half. No less than time and a half. The contractor would get double scale. And then anybody that — a composer or a conductor wanted specifically and the guy wouldn't go for time and a half, they could play them whatever they wanted. A lot of guys were getting double time and triple time because they were worth that kind of money to the conductor. And there's some musicians in L.A., I don't

they get double time and they're working all the time. It's their reputation and their ability to do the job the first time around. Because when you're doing a movie date there's a hundred people on the stage you know in the stage room, and you're recording, nobody can really make a mistake. If you do you have to stop and then they have to roll the tape back, you have to roll into the movie screen that you have playing behind you for the conductor to follow. So you know they expect you to sight read fly specks. You can't miss. So guys when they're that dependable they want 'em.

MR: That's high pressure for sure. And I can just picture the contractor like putting a check by someone who made an error. Take him off the list.

HE: Oh I know. It's that easy. I mean you have to really be on the ball and if you aren't then you're gone a lot of times unless you're really close to the contractor. And you know there are times, and you can cut this out of the thing if you want, but there were times back in the early days when guys would have these little vials of cocaine and during breaks take the contractor out and then come back and they'd always make sure that guy was in their next job. And you know it's kind of political. I hate to say it but it isn't just because you're a good player. Sometimes it's like what you have to offer too. That was then. Just like on Woody Herman's band and Maynard's band there were some junkies and you didn't have to — I mean the new kids coming up, college graduates, they — as far as I know — they're pretty clean. You know they don't do anything like that. They may have some drinks afterwards but I don't hear of anybody shooting up anymore. And now marijuana is like something where in a lot of states it's legal now. But at that time, you know that was, to play jazz you had to either shoot up or turn on. And that was just the way it was. Of course I never did that. I was offered, even when I was on Maynard's band. Maynard was taking — he was experimenting with LSD, under a doctor's care. And I was in the band for only two weeks because I took Chet Ferretti's place. He's from Buffalo I think, great trumpet player. And he went off with the trombone player that was on the band at the same time — Sonny? I'm not sure now. But they — he had a tour in Europe and he took Chet Ferretti and the rhythm section. So I replaced him on Maynard's band. But early on, in the '50s and '60s and earlier there was — drugs were a bigger deal then.

MR: It's interesting, I think technology in one respect has been helpful for that kind of thing because you've experienced those — except for riding in the Corvette — the endless hours sidemen talk about being on the bus with basically nothing to do. And with the advent of Walkmans and now the phones and everything, people can fill their time with something else that's not a health risk.

HE: Well even when I was on the bus with Warren Covington and the Tommy Dorsey band,

few guys that would play. A lot of guys would read. Most of the guys had earphones and were listening to jazz or music of some kind. So we had an opportunity to keep ourselves busy. But when we were on the road there were times after a job you'd get back in the bus either to go to a new place a hundred miles down the road or two hundred, guys would start drinking, turning on, and one time we got to the hotel and one of the guys was on the floor of the bus and he was just out. We had to carry him in the hotel. But I mean the guys were usually on the young side wanting to make it, and I don't know whether they felt doing that would make them better, you know, and attached to somebody that has a big name. I have no idea. But that wasn't me. You know I like to know what I'm always doing. A couple of times, I can count three times that I've drank to where I was drunk. And only three times. After the first time I said I'd never do it again. But then when I was in Vegas I saw this Louie Valizan who I worked with when I was 17 and now he was playing lead with Esquivel! at the Stardust Hotel and then we had tequila over and over again. And I was fine until I got out and the sun was shining in my face and I had to drive home with one eye open. And that was the second time. And one last time. And that was it. But a lot of my friends, you know they drank themselves to death. And it's a shame because a couple of them that I knew were closet drinkers. We'd be out playing golf — Warren Luening, the trumpet player, excellent trumpet player in L.A. originally from New Orleans. He and I and this other trumpet player, we'd go out and play golf and we'd go to a bar and we'd each have a drink and then leave. A glass of beer — or a bottle of beer. And then we'd leave, go home. And I never thought about him ever being a heavy drinker until he was found in his place, in his apartment dead from drinking. Just an alcoholic. And I was pretty close to him and didn't even know that. So I know at least two others that died from just drinking too much. So sometimes you have too much time on your hands and you don't want to work, you don't want to do anything else but play your instrument.

MR: Yeah. And four hours a day and then you've got to wait 'til the next day to do so. That's a lot of time to fill in. Yeah.

HE: And then the next day there may not be work. You know sometimes you have a great week where you're working a lot and bringing in a lot of money. The next week maybe one or two sessions and that's it. And you know people just don't know what to do with themselves sometimes. Some love playing golf like Carl Saunders, the trumpet player, really a great player. He was a great golfer. We'd go out and play golf. Alan Kaplan's another trombone player that used to play golf with Carl, and the three of us would go out and play and I was the worst of them. I could break a hundred but they were playing in the 70s, you know close to being a pro.

MR: I see. I wanted to wrap up just with an observation that I've been noticing and that is what used to be our word, and I'm speaking of "gig" — has now become usurped in a number of ways. I remember hearing DJs start talking about, "I have a gig tomorrow." And I remember being like don't say that, you don't have a gig. And now we have the gig economy which further usurps our own word.

HE: But Monk, I remember when I was still working the guys would always say, "I've got this gig" at so-and-so. Especially the jazz players. "I've got a gig at Donte's" or at the Lighthouse. Occasionally it would be a "job." Job is more formal. A gig was, the guys would say that among themselves. So that terminology has been around a long time in the big cities, and the outlying areas may not have picked that up as fast, but it's been around a long time.

MR: Yes. Well you've had a fruitful career and I appreciate the stories you offered today and the information about the musicians' union, which sometimes is misunderstood.

HE: Yes. When I was a player what got me involved was the president at that time made a deal with the Pantages Theater, a Neiderlander Hotel venue. And so I thought they aren't helping us. They didn't give us really an increase in wages or make anything any better. So then a friend of mine, Bob Hardaway, a tenor sax player, he was the guy that played the tenor jazz solo on the Dean Martin shows on "Everybody Loves Somebody Sometime." During the bridge he had played that solo. And he was the one that got me involved in the union. And he said, "You're always complaining" when we were doing the Ray Anthony job, during the breaks he'd say Bob — he'd say, "Hal all the time we talk you're talking about the union, how it's putting you guys down" he says, "then do something about it." He said, "I've got a spot on the Hearing Board" or at that time it was a Trial Board. He said, "Run with me." So I think it was three weekends in a row we were working with Ray Anthony together. And finally the last time I said, "Okay I'll run with you." Well after doing that, all we were doing, there were six of us spending the union's money just to say, "Hal Espinosa didn't pay his $5 fine so" they'd look it up and say, "Oh that's a $5 fine." Then he didn't pay their — whatever they were supposed to — for 25 bucks, that was a $10 fine. And it would take six of us getting paid to say that. And I thought I'm not going to do this, this is just taking money away from the guys. So then I was asked to run for the executive board and I said no. I finally ran for that, and then finally they wanted me to run for vice president. And I was already in my 60s then. So I had always thought that when I hit 50 I'd get a real job. Because playing was always fun to me. It was never a job, it was just something I loved doing, it was fun. So I figured when I hit 50 I had to start looking for a real job, you know for retirement and everything. So I could never find one. And then when I was asked to run for vice president I thought

and a few other prominent figures, "Hal you've got to do that." So I went ahead and I thought, you know it's been a fun thing to do but you know I've done it. I've had enough of it. And I thought maybe I can help others with better contracts maybe. So I ran and I won. And then I ended up being president for ten years. And the fun part about that is I was dealing with musicians that I worked with all the time. They would be on the theater committee, they'd be on the motion picture committee or the symphony orchestra committee, so I was dealing with them and still seeing all these same guys I used to work for so it was a natural for me to get in. And I loved to actually do some critical thinking at the older age of 65. So anyway I did that for ten years and then finally I had it. I could start feeling like I was sinking a little bit because we had 63 or 64 contracts that had to be negotiated at least every year, every three years, or with the L.A. Opera and the L.A. — I mean yeah, the L.A. Philharmonic. We got an attorney to set up five year agreements, which was nice.

MR: Well for a guy who couldn't find a real job I think you've done well for yourself.

HE: You know, thank you — and you know I never planned anything other than to get a degree in college, and the only time I used it was when I was in Vegas when I was working at the Dunes at Viva La Girls show. Our first show was 11:00 at night and then 1:00 in the morning and 3:00 in the morning. It was an hour and twenty minute show and 40 minutes off. And then that was the whole routine. The rest of the day until 11:00 at night was mine. So then I decided I'm going to do some teaching — substitute teaching — because I had my degree and I could do something useful during the afternoon. So I'd get to bed around 5:00 in the morning. I'd get a call at 6 to teach at North High School, and I thought well I'll do this a few times just to say I used my degree. I ended up getting called every day for that whole year, during the school days. And I went from being a Spanish teacher to an English teacher to a band teacher one time out of that whole year. But, and then the kid saw me up there and they'd start playing around on the horns, you know when I told them to stop. And then when we were playing somebody was screwing around, they didn't think I knew. I'd stop and say, "You want to stand up — you want to play a solo? Then I want to hear it. Stand up and play." Nobody would stand up because they didn't know who I was talking to. So I'd say, "You." Get all embarrassed and said, "I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I didn't mean that." So anyway I got to use my degree one time.

MR: Excellent. Well thanks for your time today, Hal. This has been very interesting. I appreciate it.

HE: Well thank you, Monk. This was a lot of fun too for me to reminisce.

MR: Good.